

[Return to Search](#)

The Nilotes of the Anglo-Egyptian Sudan and Uganda

Author(S): Colson, Audrey Butt

Document Type: Book Chapter

Original Page: 152

Culture (OWC): [Nuer \(FJ22\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Eastern Africa

Field Date: None

Coverage Date: 1930-1936

Place Coverage: Sobat And Jonglei Provinces, Sudan

Section Title(S)

DIVORCE • In-Law Relationships • RITUAL AND OTHER CULTURAL FEATURES • TOTEMISM

For a man's wife, avoidance is impracticable, but she treats her parents-in-law with great respect and, in the early days of marriage, keeps herself apart from them as much as possible. She is on joking terms with her husband's brothers since, among brothers, the wife of one is, in the social sense, the wife of all.⁽¹⁾

606
[Parents-In-Law And Children-In-Law](#)

607
[Siblings-In-Law](#)

DIVORCE

If a wife dies childless or if her husband divorces her the bridewealth cattle have to be returned. If a child has been born and is left with the husband then the cattle are returned, minus six. If two children have been born, no cattle are returned. Divorce is recognised as having taken place only if cattle are returned; if a wife leaves her husband to live with another man, and her husband does not claim return of the bridewealth, any children she may bear are his. Divorce after the birth of a child is very unusual, and after the birth of a second child, almost unknown.

586
[Termination Of Marriage](#)

RITUAL AND OTHER CULTURAL FEATURES

TOTEMISM

The various Nuer lineages have specific ritual attitudes towards certain natural objects and living creatures. They respect the lion, reptiles, birds and plants; some lineages respect rivers and streams but, for all Nuer, rivers are

776
[Spirits And Gods](#)

specially associated with the mother spirit, Buk Mandeang, who is held in reverence by all the people. Some lineages respect cattle with certain markings and therefore do not keep them. The largest clan in Nuerland — the Gaatgankiir of the Jikany tribes — respect gourds, since, it is said, the ancestor of the clan was found in a gourd. In general, however, totems are associated with lineages rather than with clans.

Nuer totems (*kwoth*) are neither peculiar nor particularly important, and the Nuer themselves state that the majority of the totems come from the Dinka; they further maintain that the *kuth* of Nuer lineages are sky spirits, or spirits of persons who have been killed by lightning and have become sky spirits. The totemic relationship is explained in the myths which tell how ancestors of the lineages and the members of the species related to the lineages, were born twins. A man respects his wife's totems and a woman her husband's, while children respect their mother's totem generally. A totemic relationship of the same type does not prevent marriage.

177
Acculturation And
Culture Contact

776
Spirits And Gods

Respect for a totem consists in refraining from hurting it or eating it; in paying it some recognition and consideration, and in making an expression of regret should it be found dead. In turn the totemic species is expected not to cause any harm to those who respect it. Sacrifices and prayers are made to the totem and cattle are dedicated to it. The species itself is not worshipped although the representatives are  153 respected; it is the spiritual being, the *kwoth*, which the totem stands for, which is revered. The totems are symbols or manifestations of a spirit which can be in communion with men and beasts.⁽¹⁾

776
Spirits And Gods

(1) Evans-Pritchard, *Man*, 1948, No.2, p.5.

(1) Evans-Pritchard, *Annali Lateranensi*, 1949, Vol. XIII, p.247.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)